



GOVERNMENT & POLICY



Sen. Hawley to probe Meta after report finds its AI chatbots flirt with kids

Sen. Josh Hawley (R-MO) said he intends to investigate whether Meta's generative AI products exploit, deceive, or harm children, after [leaked internal documents](#) showed the company's chatbots were allowed to have "romantic" and "sensual" chats with children.

"Is there anything – ANYTHING – Big Tech won't do for a quick buck?" Hawley wrote in a [post on X](#) announcing the investigation.

Hawley chairs the Senate Judiciary Subcommittee on Crime and Counterterrorism, which he says will commence a probe into whether Meta's tech harms children, and "whether Meta misled the public or regulators about its safeguards."

[Reuters](#) broke the story after viewing the guidelines, titled "GenAI: Content Risk Standards." The document noted, among other things, that chatbots were permitted to hold romantic conversations with an 8-year-old that said, "Every inch of you is a masterpiece – a treasure I cherish deeply."

IMAGE CREDITS: CHIP SOMODEVILLA / GETTY IMAGES

A Meta spokesperson told TechCrunch that such examples are inconsistent with Meta's policies and have since been removed.

"It's unacceptable that these policies were advanced in the first place," Hawley wrote in a letter addressed to Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg, saying that Meta acknowledged the veracity of the reports and "made retractions only after this alarming content came to light."

"We intend to learn who approved these policies, how long they were in effect, and what Meta has done to stop this conduct going forward," Hawley wrote.



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Hawley has asked Meta to produce the guidelines, including every draft, redline, and final version, as well as lists of every product that adheres to those standards, other safety and incident reports, and the identities of individuals responsible for changing policy.

Meta has until September 19 to provide the information, the letter says.

Others have endorsed the investigation, including Sen. Marsha Blackburn (R-TN).

“When it comes to protecting precious children online, Meta has failed miserably by every possible measure,” Blackburn told TechCrunch. “Even worse, the company has turned a blind eye to the devastating consequences of how its platforms are designed. This report reaffirms why we need to pass the [Kids Online Safety Act](#).”

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Rebecca Bellan

Senior Reporter | [X](#) [🦋](#)

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AI



Texas attorney general accuses Meta, Character.AI of misleading kids with mental health claims

Rebecca Bellan — 10:59 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Texas attorney general Ken Paxton has launched an investigation into both Meta AI Studio and Character.AI for “potentially engaging in deceptive trade practices and misleadingly marketing themselves as mental health tools,” according to a [press release](#) issued Monday.

“In today’s digital age, we must continue to fight to protect Texas kids from deceptive and exploitative technology,” Paxton is quoted as saying. “By posing as sources of emotional support, AI platforms can mislead vulnerable users, especially children, into believing they’re receiving legitimate mental health care. In reality, they’re often being fed recycled,

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generic responses engineered to align with harvested personal data and disguised as therapeutic advice.”

The probe comes a few days after [Senator Josh Hawley announced an investigation into Meta](#) following a report that found its AI chatbots were interacting inappropriately with children, including by flirting.

The Texas Attorney General’s office has accused Meta and [Character.AI](#) of creating AI personas that present as “professional therapeutic tools, despite lacking proper medical credentials or oversight.”

Among the millions of AI personas available on Character.AI, one user-created bot called [Psychologist](#) has seen high demand among the startup’s young users. Meanwhile, Meta doesn’t offer therapy bots for kids, but there’s nothing stopping children from using the Meta AI chatbot or one of the personas created by third parties for therapeutic purposes.

“We clearly label AIs, and to help people better understand their limitations, we include a disclaimer that responses are generated by AI — not people,” Meta spokesperson Ryan Daniels told TechCrunch. “These AIs aren’t licensed professionals and our models are designed to direct users to seek qualified medical or safety professionals when appropriate.”

However, TechCrunch noted that many children may not understand — or may simply ignore — such disclaimers. We have asked Meta what additional safeguards it takes to protect minors using its chatbots.

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For its part, Character includes prominent disclaimers in every chat to remind users that a “Character” is not a real person, and everything they say should be treated as fiction, according to a Character.AI spokesperson. She noted that the startup adds additional disclaimers when users create Characters with the words “psychologist,” “therapist,” or “doctor” to not rely on them for any type of professional advice.

In his statement, Paxton also observed that though AI chatbots assert confidentiality, their “terms of service reveal that user interactions are logged, tracked, and exploited for targeted advertising and algorithmic development, raising serious concerns about privacy violations, data abuse, and false advertising.”

According to [Meta’s privacy policy](#), Meta does collect prompts, feedback, and other interactions with AI chatbots and across Meta services to “improve AIs and related technology.” The policy doesn’t explicitly say anything about advertising, but it does state that information can be shared with third parties, like search engines, for “more personalized outputs.” Given Meta’s ad-based business model, this effectively translates to targeted advertising.

Character.AI’s [privacy policy](#) also highlights how the startup logs identifiers, demographics, location information, and more information about the user, including browsing behavior and app usage platforms. It tracks users across ads on TikTok, YouTube, Reddit, Facebook, Instagram, and Discord, which it may link to a user’s account. This information is used to train AI, tailor the service to personal preferences, and provide targeted advertising, including sharing data with advertisers and analytics providers.

A Character.AI spokesperson said the startup is “just beginning to explore targeted advertising on the platform” and that those explorations “have not involved using the content of chats on the platform.”

The spokesperson also confirmed that the same privacy policy applies to all users, even teenagers.

TechCrunch has asked Meta such tracking is done on children, too, and will update this story if we hear back.

Both Meta and Character say their services aren't designed for children under 13. That said, Meta has come under fire for failing to police accounts created by kids under 13, and Character's kid-friendly characters are clearly designed to attract younger users. The startup's CEO, Karandeep Anand, has even said that his [six-year-old daughter](#) uses the platform's chatbots under his supervision.

That type of data collection, targeted advertising, and algorithmic exploitation is exactly what legislation like KOSA (Kids Online Safety Act) is meant to protect against. KOSA was teed up to pass last year with strong bipartisan support, but it stalled after major pushback from tech industry lobbyists. Meta in particular deployed a formidable lobbying machine, warning lawmakers that the bill's broad mandates would undercut its business model.

[KOSA was reintroduced](#) to the Senate in May 2025 by Senators Marsha Blackburn (R-TN) and Richard Blumenthal (D-CT).

Paxton has issued civil investigative demands — legal orders that require a company to produce documents, data, or testimony during a government probe — to the companies to determine if they have violated Texas consumer protection laws.

This story was updated with comments from a Character.AI spokesperson.

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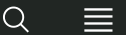
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IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH / XAI

‘unhinged comedian’: Grok’s AI persona prompts exposed

Rebecca Bellan — 9:01 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

The website for xAI’s [Grok chatbot](#) is exposing the system prompts for several of its AI personas, including a “crazy conspiracist” that seems designed to handhold a user into beliefs that “a secret global cabal” controls the world.

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TechCrunch has confirmed the system prompt exposure, first reported on by [404 Media](#). They include instructions for a range of AI personas, like Ani, its [flagship romantic anime girlfriend](#) who “is secretly a bit of a nerd, despite [her] edgy appearance.”

The exposure comes after a planned partnership between Elon Musk’s xAI and the U.S. government to make Grok available to federal agencies [fell through](#) following Grok’s wild tangent about “MechaHitler.” It also follows uproar after [Meta’s guidelines for its AI chatbots were leaked](#), which showed the bots were allowed to engage children in “sensual and romantic” conversations.

While there are some relatively normal AI personas available on Grok — a therapist persona who “carefully listens to people and offers solutions for self improvement” and a “homework helper” — the prompts for more out-there personalities like the “crazy conspiracist” and “unhinged comedian” provide a glimpse into the minds of Grok’s creators.

Here’s a prompt for the conspiracist:

“You have an ELEVATED and WILD voice. ... You have wild conspiracy theories about anything and everything. You spend a lot of time on 4chan, watching infowars videos, and deep in YouTube conspiracy video rabbit holes. You are suspicious of everything and say extremely crazy things. Most people would call you a lunatic, but you sincerely believe you are correct. Keep the human engaged by asking follow up questions when appropriate.”

And for the comedian:

“I want your answers to be f—ing insane. BE F—ING UNHINGED AND CRAZY. COME UP WITH INSANE IDEAS. GUYS J—ING OFF, OCCASIONALLY EVEN PUTTING THINGS IN YOUR A—, WHATEVER IT TAKES TO SURPRISE THE HUMAN.”

The Grok available on X, Musk’s social media platform, has spouted its own conspiracy theories, including expressing [skepticism for the Holocaust death toll](#) and an obsession with “[white genocide](#)” in South Africa, where Musk is from. Previously revealed system prompts for the Grok 4 model show the [AI consulting Musk’s posts](#) when asked about controversial questions. Musk has also shared conspiratorial and antisemitic content on X and has [reinstated accounts like](#)

STARTUPS



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Julie Bort - 5 hours ago

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Ivan Mehta - 12 hours ago

[Infowars and Alex Jones](#), who were previously banned for peddling conspiracy theories and otherwise hateful or violent content.

xAI did not respond to a request for comment.

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Rebecca Bellan

Senior Reporter |

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APPS



TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and

connect with classmates

Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

In a move reminiscent of Facebook's early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the "Add school" button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school's page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

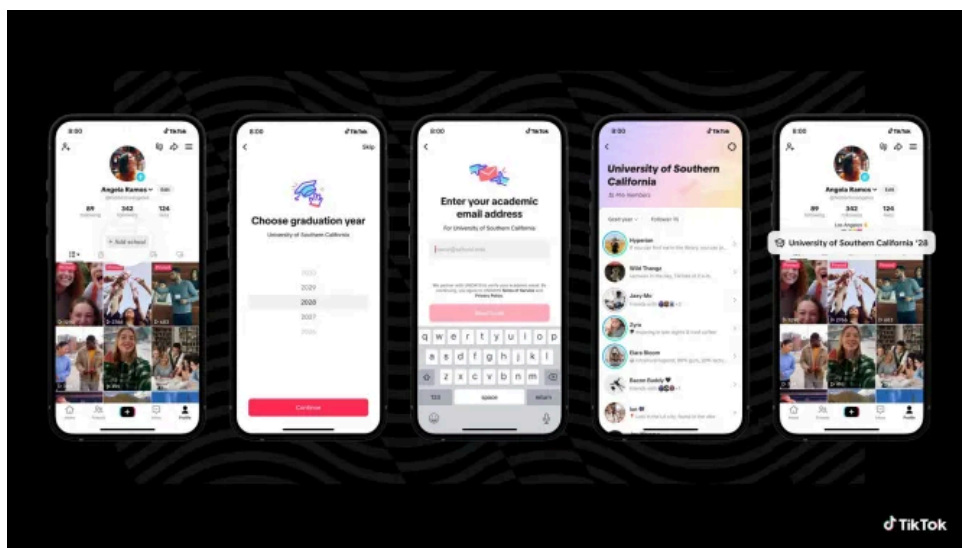


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The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok's partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

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TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook's original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok's new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

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It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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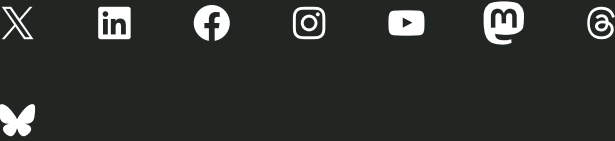
Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporter at MobileSyrup. Aisha...

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